Business

1. Chipotle recently reported quarterly results that surprised analysts. Which group of customers, for the first time this year, actually outperformed wealthier ones at Chipotle's restaurants?
   a. Students and under-25s
   b. Low-income consumers
   c. Suburban families

2. California is considering banning a popular kitchen and bathroom worktop material over serious health risks to the workers who cut and polish it. Which material is under threat?
   a. Marble
   b. Granite
   c. Quartz

3. DoorDash just announced a blockbuster $17 billion deal to buy a major rival, significantly expanding beyond restaurant deliveries into grocery. The target company's app will keep running independently after the deal closes. Which company is DoorDash acquiring?
   a. Gopuff
   b. Instacart
   c. FreshDirect

4. A zoo near Islamabad has just launched Pakistan's first attraction of its kind: visitors can sip coffee and snacks while getting up close with ten imported exotic animals. What animal is the star of the show?
   a. Capybaras
   b. Meerkats
   c. Alpacas

Economics

5. Italy's inflation (the rate at which prices rise across the economy) accelerated sharply in October to 5.4%, up from 4.2% the month before. What was the main driver pushing prices higher so quickly?
   a. A surge in food import costs
   b. Rising energy costs
   c. A weaker euro driving up consumer goods prices

6. The US Federal Trade Commission (FTC) recently ordered major airlines, ride-share companies, and retailers to hand over data about their pricing systems. What practice is the regulator investigating?
   a. Hidden subscription fees buried in loyalty programmes
   b. Algorithmic pricing — using software to charge different people different prices for the same thing
   c. Price-fixing agreements between rival companies

7. Honda recently warned that a threatened US tariff (a tax on imported goods) hike on Canadian vehicles and parts would be 'catastrophic' for the North American auto industry. What tariff rate is being threatened on Canadian cars?
   a. 35%
   b. 50%
   c. 65%

8. A recent analysis found that one group of Americans has dramatically improved its financial position since 2019, contradicting the gloomy economic mood many people feel. How much has the net worth (total assets minus debts) of the bottom half of Americans changed since 2019?
   a. It has grown by about 30%
   b. It has roughly stayed the same in real terms
   c. It has more than doubled

General Knowledge

9. Which country is the world's largest producer of coffee, accounting for roughly a third of global output?
   a. Colombia
   b. Vietnam
   c. Brazil

10. Which 18th-century economist wrote the foundational text of modern capitalism, arguing that individuals pursuing their own self-interest unintentionally benefit society — a concept he called the 'invisible hand'?
   a. David Ricardo
   b. Adam Smith
   c. Thomas Malthus

Business

1. Chipotle recently reported quarterly results that surprised analysts. Which group of customers, for the first time this year, actually outperformed wealthier ones at Chipotle's restaurants?

b. Low-income consumers outperformed high-income ones at Chipotle for the first time this year. The CEO flagged this as a sign of resilience across the income spectrum, helping push shares up 7% after results. It matters because much of the recent worry about consumer spending has focused on lower earners pulling back — this suggests that pressure may be easing.

2. California is considering banning a popular kitchen and bathroom worktop material over serious health risks to the workers who cut and polish it. Which material is under threat?

c. Quartz is the material facing a potential California ban. Cutting and grinding engineered quartz releases fine silica dust, which can cause silicosis — a severe and irreversible lung disease. The threat of regulation has already pushed contractors and retailers to explore alternatives, making this a rare case where a health scandal is reshaping an entire construction sector in real time.

3. DoorDash just announced a blockbuster $17 billion deal to buy a major rival, significantly expanding beyond restaurant deliveries into grocery. The target company's app will keep running independently after the deal closes. Which company is DoorDash acquiring?

b. DoorDash is buying Instacart for $17 billion in one of the biggest grocery-delivery deals ever. The Instacart brand and app will remain separate, which suggests DoorDash wants to hold onto Instacart's loyal customer base rather than absorbing it. The deal reflects a broader squeeze in delivery: companies that once survived on restaurant orders alone are racing to own the grocery aisle too.

4. A zoo near Islamabad has just launched Pakistan's first attraction of its kind: visitors can sip coffee and snacks while getting up close with ten imported exotic animals. What animal is the star of the show?

c. Alpacas are the attraction — the zoo is offering a 'Coffee with Alpaca' experience where visitors can feed and pet the animals over a hot drink. It's a format that has taken off in Japan and parts of Europe, but this is a first for Pakistan. The alpacas were imported specifically for the attraction, which says something interesting about how animal-café culture is quietly going global.

Economics

5. Italy's inflation (the rate at which prices rise across the economy) accelerated sharply in October to 5.4%, up from 4.2% the month before. What was the main driver pushing prices higher so quickly?

b. Rising energy costs were the primary cause of Italy's inflation jump to 5.4% in October. Energy prices are particularly volatile and can move headline inflation quickly — when gas and electricity bills spike, almost every other price follows eventually, since energy is an input to producing and transporting nearly everything. Italy's statistics agency Istat flagged the energy component as the key culprit behind the sharp acceleration from September's 4.2%.

6. The US Federal Trade Commission (FTC) recently ordered major airlines, ride-share companies, and retailers to hand over data about their pricing systems. What practice is the regulator investigating?

b. The FTC is targeting algorithmic pricing — where companies use automated systems to vary prices in real time based on who is buying, when, and how. The concern is that algorithms, when used across an industry, can quietly push prices higher for everyone without any executive ever picking up the phone to a competitor. Delta, Uber and several retailers are among those ordered to disclose how their systems work.

7. Honda recently warned that a threatened US tariff (a tax on imported goods) hike on Canadian vehicles and parts would be 'catastrophic' for the North American auto industry. What tariff rate is being threatened on Canadian cars?

b. The threatened rate is 50%, double the current 25% tariff already in place on Canadian vehicles. Honda's stark language reflects how deeply integrated the North American car industry is — parts routinely cross the US-Canada border multiple times before a finished vehicle rolls off the line. A 50% tariff would not just raise prices; it could make entire production configurations economically unviable.

8. A recent analysis found that one group of Americans has dramatically improved its financial position since 2019, contradicting the gloomy economic mood many people feel. How much has the net worth (total assets minus debts) of the bottom half of Americans changed since 2019?

c. The net worth of the bottom half of Americans has more than doubled since 2019 — a striking figure that most people would not guess. Low starting points partly explain the scale, but wage growth, pandemic-era transfers, and rising home values all played a role. The analysis also argues that social media algorithms amplify negative economic stories, leaving many people feeling worse off than the data suggests they actually are.

General Knowledge

9. Which country is the world's largest producer of coffee, accounting for roughly a third of global output?

c. Brazil is by far the world's largest coffee producer, responsible for around 35-40% of global supply. It has held that position for over 150 years. Vietnam is second — a fact that surprises many people — while Colombia, despite having the most famous coffee brand identity, ranks third. Brazil's dominance means a drought or frost there can move global coffee prices almost instantly.

10. Which 18th-century economist wrote the foundational text of modern capitalism, arguing that individuals pursuing their own self-interest unintentionally benefit society — a concept he called the 'invisible hand'?

b. Adam Smith published 'The Wealth of Nations' in 1776 — the same year as the American Declaration of Independence — and the coincidence felt fitting to many at the time. His 'invisible hand' idea holds that free markets, through price signals and competition, coordinate economic activity more efficiently than any central planner could. Smith was Scottish, and his face appeared on the British £20 note for many years.